

FREE SAMPLE

African Fat-Tailed Gecko Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 45-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, Fat-Tail or Leopard Gecko? The Differences. The contents page shows every one of the 45 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 40 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/african-fat-tail/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free African fat-tailed gecko care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/african-fat-tail/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't bought a gecko yet

Read page 5 first. The African fat-tailed gecko is sold beside the leopard gecko, looks like it, and is often set up like it, and the differences on that page are the ones that decide whether a fat-tail sheds cleanly. Then read pages 6 through 11 in order before buying anything, and the feeding section after that. Use the Budget and Shopping List on page 32 to buy once instead of twice.

If your gecko is already home

Start with the Setup Checklist on page 30 to audit what you have. Then check the humid hide on page 8: retained shed on the toes and tail tip is the most common health complaint in this species, and a hide that has dried out is usually why. If you came here asking what a fat-tail eats, the feeding section starts on page 12. If anything already looks wrong, go straight to Health Red Flags on page 23.

Print these first

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| ☐ Page 30: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 13: Feeding Schedule by Age |
| ☐ Page 31: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 38: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 35: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 39: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 36: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 40: Equipment, Supplement & Vet Log |

How the numbers are written

Every temperature is given in °F (degrees Fahrenheit) and °C (degrees Celsius), and every length as in (inches) and cm (centimeters), with mm (millimeters) for the smallest prey. Weights are in g (grams), because this gecko is small enough that a change of a few grams matters. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Every abbreviation and technical word is spelled out the first time it appears.

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

The fat-tail is usually sold as a leopard gecko with a different pattern, and set up the way a leopard gecko is. Most of that setup transfers. The part that does not is moisture: this gecko comes from the savannas of West Africa rather than the dry rock country of southern Asia, it needs a wetter enclosure and a humid hide that is never allowed to dry, and the most common fat-tail health problem traces straight back to that gap. Every figure here is cross-checked against the veterinary sources listed on page 43.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian who sees reptiles. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care, and anything urgent is a professional call, not a page in this book. Not every practice treats reptiles, so find one before you need one and write the number on page 31.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Hemitheconyx caudicinctus</i> . A eublepharid, one of the eyelid geckos: the same family as the leopard gecko, with true eyelids and no sticky toe pads
Native range	West Africa, from Senegal to Cameroon. Savanna, dry forest and rocky scrubland, sleeping by day under rocks, surface debris or in an abandoned burrow
Adult size	7 to 9 in (18 to 23 cm). Hatchlings are about 2 in (5 cm). Males grow larger than females
Adult weight	40 to 90 g, averaging about 50 g. Page 21
Captive lifespan	15 to 20 years, and the best-documented captive record is just over 16 years. Plan on well over a decade
Activity	Nocturnal. Asleep in a hide by day, hunting on the ground at night
Diet	Live insects only: an obligate insectivore, meaning it must eat insects and cannot use plant food. Page 12
Enclosure, one adult	36×18×18 in (91×46×46 cm) as the minimum. A 40-gallon breeder tank, 36×18×16 in (91×46×41 cm), gives the same floor. Floor space, not height
Temperature	Warm side 88 to 92°F (31 to 33°C) at the surface, cool side 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C), night 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C). Page 7
Humidity	50 to 70% through the enclosure, with a permanent humid hide at 70 to 80%. Higher than a leopard gecko. Page 8
UVB (ultraviolet B)	The band of ultraviolet light a reptile uses to make vitamin D3 in its skin. Optional for this species if it gets a calcium powder with D3, but a low-output 2 to 5% UVB tube is increasingly recommended. Page 9
Most common problem	Retained shed on the toes and tail tip, almost always from low humidity or no humid hide. Page 24
Handling	One of the calmest pet geckos, often called more docile than the leopard gecko. Never by the tail
Conservation status	Least Concern, the lowest-risk grade on the global list of species at risk. Buy captive-bred

Cost overview

Initial setup

The gecko is \$75 to \$600, with normals commonly around \$100 and fancier color lines, called morphs, costing more. The setup, with the first supplements, comes to **\$485 to \$835**. With a first exam and fecal test (a stool check for parasites), plan on **\$585 to \$1,050** before the gecko. Page 32.

Ongoing

Feeders and supplements run **\$10 to \$25 a month**, or \$120 to \$300 a year. With a yearly exam and fecal test and two UVB tubes a year, a healthy adult runs about **\$270 to \$570 a year**. A sick visit with tests is typically \$150 to \$300 or more.

THE NUMBER THAT SHOULD DRIVE THE DECISION

Not the price. The lifespan. Over 15 years, the yearly costs alone come to about \$4,050 to \$8,550 on top of the gecko and the first setup. The purchase is the cheap part, and the routine on page 36 is what you are actually signing up for.

Fat-tail or leopard gecko? The differences

Same family, same shape, same shop shelf. Not the same setup.

The African fat-tailed gecko and the leopard gecko are both eublepharids: ground-dwelling geckos with eyelids, no climbing pads, a fat-storing tail, and a habit of dropping that tail when grabbed. Most of what a leopard gecko owner knows does transfer. Three things do not: humidity, temperament and origin. A fat-tail kept exactly like a leopard gecko usually goes wrong on humidity.

	AFRICAN FAT-TAILED GECKO	LEOPARD GECKO
Origin	West Africa, Senegal to Cameroon: savanna, dry forest and rocky scrub	Pakistan, Afghanistan, Iran, India and Nepal: rocky desert, arid grassland and dry scrub
Humidity	50 to 70% through the enclosure, plus a humid hide at 70 to 80% that is a permanent fixture	30 to 40% through the enclosure, with a humid hide at 70 to 80%
Temperament	Among the calmest pet geckos, often described as even more docile. More vocal than most pet geckos	Calm and easy to handle once settled
Underfoot	A burrower: a soil and sand mix at least 4 in (10 cm) deep for healthy adults	Paper towel or tile is the usual default, with a dig box as enrichment
Belly heat	88 to 92°F (31 to 33°C) at the warm side surface, cool side 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C)	88 to 92°F (31 to 33°C) at the warm hide, cool side about 70 to 77°F (21 to 25°C)
Enclosure	36×18×18 in (91×46×46 cm) minimum	36×18×18 in (91×46×46 cm) is now the minimum
Nest choice	Gravid females, those carrying eggs, chose nest sites averaging 32.4°C (about 90°F)	Gravid females chose 28.7°C (about 84°F)
Price	\$75 to \$600, normals around \$100	\$20 to \$45 for a standard animal from a store

Why humidity is the one that matters

Stuck shed on the toes and the tip of the tail is the most common fat-tail-specific health complaint, and it shows up when the enclosure runs too dry or the humid hide is missing or dried out. A ring of old skin left on a toe tightens as it dries and can cut off the blood supply. A leopard gecko setup, copied exactly, produces the drier enclosure that causes it. The fix is not a wet tank: the enclosure stays mostly dry, at 50 to 70%, and the moisture lives in one damp hide. Page 8 has the setup and page 24 the problem.

DO NOT RAISE HUMIDITY EVERYWHERE

Going the other way is its own mistake. An enclosure that is too damp and too cool at the same time is what causes respiratory infection in this species (page 26). Humid in the hide, moderate in the air, warm at one end.

SAME FAMILY, SAME HABITS

What carries straight across from a leopard gecko: belly heat from a mat on a thermostat, three hides, live insects dusted with calcium, a tail that is never a handhold, and the tail as the body-condition gauge. If you have kept a leopard gecko, you already know most of this book. Read the humidity and substrate pages twice.